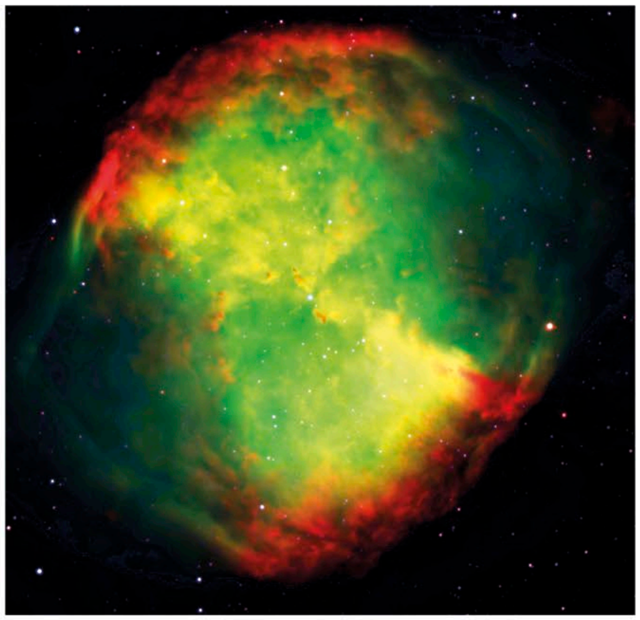
VULPECULA

THE FOX

A FAINT NORTHERN CONSTELLATION NEAR THE HEAD OF CYGNUS, THE SWAN, VULPECULA WAS INTRODUCED AT THE END OF THE 17TH CENTURY BY THE POLISH ASTRONOMER JOHANNES HEVELIUS. IT CONTAINS A FAMOUS PLANETARY NEBULA, THE DUMBBELL.

Johannes Hevelius originally called this constellation *Vulpecula cum Ansere*, the fox and goose, but modern astronomers have simplified the name to just Vulpecula. It consists of a scattering of stars of 4th magnitude and fainter in the Milky Way south of Cygnus. On its southern border with Sagitta lies a grouping called Brocchi's Cluster. Through binoculars, this group appears as a line of six stars with a protruding hook, reminiscent of a coat hanger, which gives rise to its popular name, the Coathanger. However, it is not a true cluster, because all its stars are at different distances from us. Another celebrated object in Vulpecula is M27, a planetary nebula popularly known as the Dumbbell from its supposed resemblance to a barbell used for weight training.



◁ **Dumbbell Nebula**
A well-known planetary nebula also known as M27, the Dumbbell lies about 1,200 light-years away. It consists of gas ejected from a dying star, the exposed core of which can be seen as a faint white dot at the centre of this image.

KEY **DATA**

Size ranking 55

Brightest stars Alpha (α) 4.5, 13 Vulpeculae 4.6

Genitive Vulpeculae

Abbreviation Vul

Highest in sky at 10pm August–September

Fully visible 90°N–61°S

CHART 4

MAIN **STARS**

Alpha (α) Vulpeculae
Red giant
4.5 ⟷ 297 light-years

T Vulpeculae
Variable yellow-white supergiant
5.4–6.1 ⟷ 1,200 light-years

DEEP-SKY **OBJECTS**

M27 (Dumbbell Nebula)
Planetary nebula about 1,200 light-years away

Brocchi's Cluster (Collinder 399; "the Coathanger")
Grouping of 10 unrelated stars